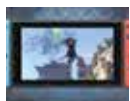




Agent 47 returns

Hitman 2 has been announced and will be available on the PlayStation 4, Windows PC and Xbox One from November this year. <https://dgit.in/jul18-65-1>

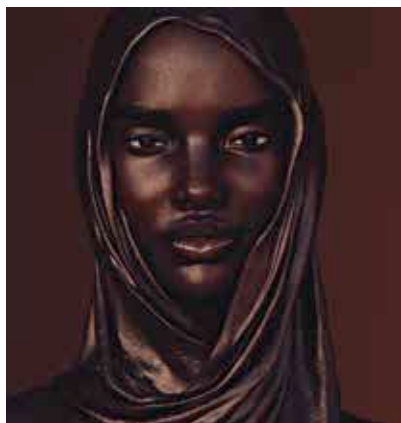


Paladins on the Switch

Hi-Rez Studios announced that their hero-shooter game, Paladins, would arrive on the Nintendo Switch on June 12. <https://dgit.in/jul18-65-2>

top of that, being controlled by a team that engineers each and every aspect of their existence makes them predictable – a factor favoured a lot by brands in comparison to real life influencers who can be prone to controversy and errors (remember the Logan Paul controversy?).

Also, social media today has reached a pretty high degree of falsehood in terms of appearance and standards. Smartphone today launch with camera APIs that boast of powerful 'beautification' features. Real life influencers like Kylie Jenner have evolved over time, through cosmetic surgery, to reach an unprecedented degree of artificial appearance. In such an environment, it isn't a surprise that these virtual influencers garnered popularity. Most celebrity and popular social media handles are managed by entire teams already, so even that aspect of a virtual influencers existence doesn't really become a roadblock to their popularity.



Shudu Gram has been even criticized for being something similar to blackface minstrels of the mid-1800s, which allowed people to interact with black people without actually doing it

THE PROBLEMS WITH CGI INFLUENCERS

Aside from the obvious implications on pushing unreal standards of beauty and good looks to a whole new, engineered level, the rise of CGI influencers comes with its own set of problems that must be dealt with soon.

To start off, there is the question of accountability. In the current state of



A still from *Le Congrès*, the Robin Wright starrer that explores the idea of celebrities selling the rights to their virtual avatars

technology, it is impossible for a virtual influencer to actually try the products they are endorsing. It is too easy for Miquela to tell you that the Prada jacket fits like magic and feels good on the skin. Which brings us to the next problem - the difference between sponsored and non-sponsored content. Real life influencers are required by the platform or the community to declare sponsored content in some form - in text, through hashtags or more. Do CGI influencers adhere to the same standards? Should they?

While it is good to applaud the efforts of personas like Miquela standing behind important causes and influencing their followers to do the same, is it entirely impossible to think of a situation where a similar influencer is used to push an undesirable, hateful agenda onto unsuspecting masses? Remember, we're people who get influenced by targeted advertising and we're talking about entire targeted and custom engineered persona here.

In the future, celebrities and influencers might sell the rights to their CGI avatars and personas, much akin to what happens in the 2013 feature film *The Congress* (starring Robin Wright as Robin Wright). The existing popularity of a celebrity couple with near-life like avatars can provide a high level of power into the hands of whoever is wielding it. That future isn't too far away.

THE FUTURE OF CGI INFLUENCERS

Do not worry about a horde of virtual avatars and bots controlling the

thoughts of the general populace, what is more likely to happen is that brands are likely to craft their own influencers. These influencers are likely to be lifelike and created along the lines of the brand's existing image. Quantum Capture is a startup working that area. Founded in 2015, they've already worked on impressive facial scan projects such as *Death Stranding* and *Far Cry primal*. Their primary offering is photorealistic virtual human representation for chatbots.

Remember *The Congress*? Shushila Takao has already modelled for the Autodesk Virtual Assistant (AVA). Although it is not modelled after her real life persona and a publicly accessible



AVA (Autodesk Virtual Assistant) created by Soul Machines in the likeness of Shushila Takao

demo is still far away, the results are pretty impressive (<https://dgit.in/ava>). So, if John Legend can soon voice your Google Assistant, maybe David Beckham, almost in person, can welcome you to a 5-star in the UK?

We live in a world where we are increasingly relying on the opinion of machines, generated based on massive data banks on one side and corporate interests on another. It may soon become difficult to tell the real people from the created one. As of today, the difference between the CGI influencers and real-life influencers remains very little. The question is, does it really matter if an influencer is also in meatspace or not? Do let us know by writing in to editor@digit.in